

Torn Minds

Free, but fractured. As the world slept on the midnight of August 14, 1947, Jawaharlal Nehru, India's first prime minister, stood in the Constituent Assembly and announced freedom with poetic flourish: "Long years ago, we made a tryst with destiny and now the time comes when we shall redeem our pledge." India emerged out of the long night of colonialism only to be feted in blood and

when in jail, they were asked to name their parentage and the entire crowd replied in unison: "Father: Mahatma Gandhi; mother: India"—a far cry from today's dynastic politics. "Gandhi, Nehru and Patel stood for ideals that went beyond freedom. It was not just about getting rid of foreigners but how you got rid of them," says historian Ramachandra Guha.

Even 60 years later, there are many untold stories. Now a sprightly 78, Pratima Kaushik was only 13 when sentenced to two-and-half months in Lahore Women's Jail during the 1942 Quit India Movement. Dressed in a frock, little Pratima hopped around Delhi exhorting DCM Mill workers to



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CIVIL WAR: Congressmen strike, Bombay, 1942

hate. Freedom meant Partition, as India and Pakistan. The minds of the liberated too were partitioned, one of the most decisive mutilations in history. The script of sanguineous hate would be played out many more times in Independent India, in varying versions, always revealing the unhealed minds of the liberated.

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strike and attend surreptitious meetings called by nationalist leader Aruna Asaf Ali. One day, past curfew time, while she was still out distributing pamphlets against the British, an officer offered to drop her home in his jeep. Shoving the pamphlets into her underwear, she sat stiff, trying not to crinkle the paper. Unwilling to lead the officer to her home in Jawahar Nagar, where Ali was hiding, she got dropped off a few blocks away. For today's generation, this is the stuff Bollywood films are made of. But for Pratima, Vijay and others of their time, this was their childhood. It was the worst of times, but they ensured it became the best of times. ■